Royalty is getting recognition elsewhere, too. Gujarat, for instance, is planning to dedicate a whole museum—the Museum of Royal Kingdoms of India (MORKI)—to record the contributions of the princely states (see *Mission Museum*). Expected to open in 2027, the Rs 260 crore project will come up next to the Statue of Unity in the Narmada Valley.

The BJP is clearly going through a phase of royal obsession. Aditya Pratap Deo, associate professor of History at St Stephen's College, Delhi, and member of the erstwhile royal family of Kanker in Chhattisgarh, explains it thus: "The BJP and RSS represent a form of cultural nationalism where custom, tradition and history form the bedrock of their political imagery of a pristine nation. As polities described as monarchial have been the commonest and most remarkable type of high politics and political system in South Asia, and been integral to a certain understanding of the nature of Indian civilisation, they have found greater acceptance in the political discourse of post-liberal India."

PALACE TO POLLS

From the north to the south: A selection of some of the prominent personalities in the BJP from former royal families across the country

JYOTIRADITYA SCINDIA, 54

Madhya Pradesh

The Union minister hails from the Gwalior ex-ruling family and began his career in the Congress



ANANT MAHARAJ, 66

West Bengal

Also known as Nagendra Ray, the chief of the Greater Cooch Behar Democratic Party was elected unopposed to the Rajya Sabha with the BJP support

DUSHYANT SINGH, 51

Rajasthan

The five-term MP from Jhalawar is former CM and former Union minister Vasundhara Raje's son and belongs to the former ruling family of Dholpur from his father's side



DEVENDRA PRATAP SINGH, 50

Chhattisgarh

A member of the Raigarh ruling family, the Rajya Sabha member also comes from a tribal background

VISHVARAJ SINGH MEWAR, 56

Rajasthan

A member of the erstwhile House of Mewar, he is a BJP MLA. His father, the late Mahendra Singh, was a parliamentarian and his wife Mahima Kumari is a BJP MP

PROJECT RAJ

AS THE BJP EXPANDS ITS REACH ACROSS THE COUNTRY'S GEOGRAPHIES AND COMMUNITIES, IT HAS BEEN SEEKING ICONS IT CAN USE TO RALLY VOTERS. ROYALS FULFIL THAT PURPOSE EQUALLY

Though the Congress has counted many royals in its ranks—Karan Singh, the titular maharaja of the princely state of Jammu and Kashmir, Amarinder Singh (now in the BJP) of the Patiala royal family, the late Madhavrao Scindia of the erstwhile Gwalior ruling family, Rajya Sabha member and former MP CM Digvijaya Singh of Raghogarh the most prominent among them—the party's relationship with the princely states was always prickly since the abolition of the privy purses in 1971 besides the withdrawal of other privileges, such as the right to hold an unspecified number of weapons and use royal titles. The following year, as former IAS officer Ranjitsinh, member of the erstwhile ruling family of Wankaner, points out, "The Wildlife Protection Act hit the former royals' fortunes not just because they indulged in *shikaar* but also because many of them ran commercial *shikaar* companies that attracted foreign clients."

More recently, in a media article in November 2024, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi drew the ire of several erstwhile rulers when he referred to maharajas and nawabs as collaborators of the East India Company.

The BJP is now seeking to correct this 'historical wrong', which it sees as a one-sided narrative spread by the colonialists to suit their interests. "Royal families," says Dr Pankaj Sharma, director of the department of archaeology and museums in the Gujarat government, "were often painted as antagonists who were bad administrators, disliked by the locals, and who succumbed to the British Raj, compromising public interests, to maintain their privileges. Their contributions and sacrifices in integrating with the Union of India, the public welfare initiatives, their rich cultural heritage, stories of their valour and service to society have been overlooked."

The RSS is in agreement with the BJP's viewpoint. "The RSS is absolutely in agreement with monarchy. It is in keeping with the concept of Hindutva. India's glorious past includes royalty, which needs to be celebrated," says a source close to the Sangh. Plus, the fact that many former royals continue to control trusts that administer temples helps the BJP's Hindutva push.

There is, of course, a political logic to the BJP's royal overtures. As the